farm laws. To compensate for the loss of pooled votes from that side, and simultaneously try and dent Channi's Dalit support, it has tied up with the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP). Promising change, the AAP has nominated as its chief ministerial candidate the two-term Lok Sabha member Bhagwant Singh Mann, a satirist whose famous one-liners have lit up the party's campaign. Adding to the jamboree is a new political formation of Punjab farmers, led by Balbir Singh Rajewal, one of the frontmen of the farm agitation that had successfully got the Modi government to repeal the farm laws. Called the Sanyukt Samaj Morcha (SSM), this collective of 22 farm unions is widely expected to cut into AAP votes, even if its primarily Jat Sikh colours have set off a counter-mobilisation among both Dalits and trading caste Hindus. All these fluid variables make this an entertaining potboiler, but its outcome will have far-reaching consequences for the state and the country.

Channi: The Dark Horse

When Rahul Gandhi called the 58-year-old Channi to inform him about his anointment as chief minister, he wept freely. In a state where leadership has been the preserve of Jat Sikhs, the nomination of Channi, a Dalit, was at first seen as a masterstroke by the Congress—helping it offset the odour left behind by Amarinder's messy departure. The son of a tent owner of modest means, Channi joined the Congress in 2012—ironically, when Amarinder chose him over a Congress rebel. He then also made Channi the cabinet minister for technical education when the Congress came to power in 2017. The reversal of fortunes has left a trail of personal pique, and loaded repartee. Amarinder thinks Channi was a competent minister but has "no bandwidth to be a chief minister". Channi brushes aside this deprecating assessment from his former boss, saying, "I am from a poor family, he is from a rich family.



CONGRESS

CM candidate
CHARANJIT SINGH CHANNI, 58
Alliance partner: None

STRENGTHS

- Party's strong organisational structure
- Dalit support (32 per cent of voters) because of Channi, Punjab's first Dalit CM
- Goodwill among Punjabi Hindus for dealing with militancy with an iron fist
- Channi's selection as CM candidate ends the infighting on this issue

CHALLENGES

- Could lose Jat Sikh support due to choice of Dalit as CM candidate
- Factionalism has grown stronger since Amarinder's departure
- Party forced to give tickets to many sitting MLAs for fear of defections
- PCC chief Navjot Singh Sidhu is seen as disruptive

How can he accept the fact that the poor man's son is now a CM?" Channi believes that Amarinder, in joining hands with the BJP, has taken with him the anti-incumbency baggage that the Congress would otherwise have been left holding.

Although initially adjudged to be an innocuous stopgap CM, the beneficiary of feelgood tokenism before a dodgy election, the new chief minister proved wilier than his detractors had bargained for. After taking over, Channi launched a freebie spree, reducing power tariffs and waiving old dues for 5 million consumers, among other things. He then took on what he called "established mafias" by reducing the rates for sand by almost two-thirds and lodging an FIR against Bikram Singh Majithia, the brother-in-law of Sukhbir Badal, for a case involving illicit drugs. That saw his stock rise. He endeared himself further to Punjab's public by dancing the bhangra at functions, stopping and chatting with bystanders during road trips and generally making himself accessible to the public—a stark contrast to Amarinder's reclusiveness and perceived hauteur. While Amarinder is known to enjoy gourmet food, Channi is content with the common man's meal: a paratha and pickle topped with hot tea. He is also a hard taskmaster and sets an example—rising early morning and working till late into the night.

Channi then got the better of Sidhu in the leadership struggle last week when he was declared the chief ministerial candidate for the upcoming poll. Till that time, the Congress had stayed tactically neutral, saying it would fight the polls under the collective leadership of a formidable trio: Channi (Dalit),